

Chapter

Affection, Friendship and Respect — The Forms of Love and Learning It from the Guru



Introduction: Love Is Not Limited to One Relationship

We often tie the word "love" to a single relationship. But in this short discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji looks at love far more broadly. His question is simple — what is love? — and his first answer breaks our narrow idea of it:

"Love does not happen only in marriage; love happens everywhere else too."

Love is present in every relationship of life — with those younger, those of equal age, and those older.

1. The Three Kinds of Love

Acharya Ji divides love into three forms, based on age and relationship:

"So love will be of three kinds — one with a small child, that is, with someone younger than you; with someone of your own age; and with someone older than you."

And each form has its own name:

"For someone younger than you, we call it affection (**sneh**) and so on. For an equal, we call it love, or friendship, or some such name. For those above us, we refer to it as reverence and respect."

So love is one, but its form changes with the relationship:

- **Affection (sneh)** — towards those younger, such as children
- **Love or friendship** — towards those of one's own age, one's equals
- **Reverence and respect** — towards those older

Affection, friendship and reverence are not separate feelings; they are three forms of the same love.

2. The Fourth Form: Love for the Guru and the Honourable

After these three, Acharya Ji speaks of a fourth place:

"There is a fourth, where I go to the Guru or to some honourable people. Even if I go to a king, there too I can express love."

And among all of these, the highest place belongs to the Guru:

"So the highest among them will be the Guru."

Among all the forms of love, love for the Guru holds the highest place.

3. The First Door to Learning Love: The Guru

Now the question arises — when love exists in so many forms, where does one begin to learn it? Acharya Ji asks this very question himself:

"So first of all, where must I learn love, where must I go? We have now been told to practise **advait** with everyone."

Here **advait** means "not two" — no division between oneself and another, seeing the One in all. Holding such a feeling towards everyone is not easy, so Acharya Ji's answer is clear:

"First of all, go to the Guru, because he himself would be practising **advait** with all of them. Understand that love from him."

One goes to the Guru because he himself practises **advait** with everyone — love can only be learned from one who

lives it.

4. Love Learned from the Guru, in Every Relationship

Once love is understood from the Guru, all other relationships become clear by themselves:

"Then how to be with a child, then how to be with those of your age, then how to be with your elders — all of that you will understand on your own."

And the final fruit of this learning is a deep realisation:

"It is possible to love all as God."

One who has learned love from the Guru can love everyone — younger, equal and elder — as God.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 Love does not happen only in marriage — it is present in every relationship of life.

- 2** Love has three forms — affection for those younger, love or friendship for equals, and reverence and respect for elders.
- 3** The fourth form is love for the Guru and honourable people, and among them all, the Guru holds the highest place.
- 4** To learn love, first go to the Guru, because he himself practises advait with everyone.
- 5** Once love is understood from the Guru, how to be with children, equals and elders becomes clear by itself.
- 6** It is possible to love all as God.